



Slater's Mill, 1793

An English immigrant, Samuel Slater, established this water-powered textile mill in Pawtucket, Rhode Island. The valley of the Connecticut River soon became America's first major industrial region.

1803 Louisiana Purchase: France, having regained Louisiana from Spain in 1800, sells it to the US for about \$15 million. The purchase effectively doubles the size of the United States, extending its western borders to the Rocky Mountains.

1801–05 Barbary Wars: US naval forces clash with the “Barbary States” of North Africa (Algiers, Morocco, and Libya) over raids on American shipping and the states’ demands for bribes to cease the attacks and to release captured sailors. A peace treaty, signed in June 1805 and ratified by the Senate in 1806, largely ends the conflict.

1804–06 Meriwether Lewis, secretary to President Jefferson, and William Clark are sent by the president to explore the newly acquired territory of Louisiana. They set off up the Missouri River from St. Charles, Missouri, in the hope of finding a route along the Columbia River to the Pacific coast. Although they reach the Pacific in 1805, the route they find is not easy. They do, however, make useful contact with many native peoples.



Lewis and Clark

Officially known as the “Corps of Discovery,” Lewis and Clark’s expedition to explore Louisiana included Sacagawea, a young woman of the Shoshone American Indian nation, who proved invaluable as an interpreter. She is shown here standing behind Lewis and Clark.

1809 Jefferson is succeeded as president first by James Madison and then, in 1817, by James Monroe, both associated with Jefferson’s Democratic–Republican movement. This movement stresses states’ rights as opposed to the federalist views of the second president, John Adams.

1810 US annexes west Florida.

1812–14 US at war with Britain because of Britain’s refusal to recognize American commercial neutrality during Britain’s lengthy war with Napoleonic France. The US tries but fails to dislodge the British from Canada; in response the British invade and in 1814 burn Washington. A peace treaty is signed in Ghent, in what is now Belgium, but news arrives too late to prevent General Andrew Jackson’s forces from inflicting a massive defeat on the British at New Orleans in January 1815.

1817 Mississippi is admitted as the 20th state of the Union, followed by Illinois in 1818 and Alabama in 1819.

1817–18 First war against the Seminole people of Florida. After a second war in 1835–42, many Seminoles are forcibly relocated to Oklahoma.

1818 The lengthy border between the US and Canada west of the Great Lakes to the Rocky Mountains is fixed at the 49th parallel, with the US gaining the Red River Colony in what is now Northern Dakota and Minnesota.

1819 Spain cedes Florida to the US.

1820 The Missouri Compromise allows slavery in the new state of Missouri but outlaws it north and west of the Missouri River. There were fears when Missouri applied for statehood in 1819 that the balance of 11 slave-owning and 11 free states already in the Union would be upset. The northern states strongly object to slavery, but the Constitutional

Convention of 1787, while prohibiting the import of slaves, protected slavery from federal interference. The Missouri Compromise allowed the slave state of Missouri to join at the same time as the free state of Maine, thus balancing both interests within the Union.

1823 The Monroe Doctrine asserts US supremacy in the western hemisphere and warns European powers against any attempts at colonization in the Americas.

1825 John Quincy Adams becomes the sixth president after a contested election in which Andrew Jackson, hero of New Orleans, received more popular votes but lost when the election became a contingent election decided by the House of Representatives.

1828 The Democratic–Republican movement becomes the Democratic Party as Andrew Jackson is elected president. The party holds its first national presidential nominations in 1832.

1830 The Indian Removal Act allows for the permanent removal of American Indians from their land; an act of 1834 sets up the Indian Territory in what is now Arkansas. Cherokees, Seminoles, Creeks, and others are all forcibly moved.

1836 Texas declares independence from Mexico. After a Texan garrison is massacred at the Alamo in San Antonio, the Texans defeat a Mexican army at San Jacinto, winning their independence.

1841 William Henry Harrison is inaugurated as the ninth president on March 4 but dies a month later. Vice president John Tyler succeeds him.

1842 Under the Webster–Ashburton Treaty the northeast border of the US with British Canada is finally settled.

1845 Texas is annexed to the US.

1845 Congress fixes the date of future presidential elections on the Tuesday following the first Monday in November.

1846 Britain and the US agree to divide Oregon Country between them along the 49th parallel. President James Polk had claimed the whole of the territory up to the southern border of Russian Alaska with a cry of “54° 40’ or fight!” Had he won, the US would have excluded British Canada from the Pacific coastline.

1846–48 Mexico is defeated in the Mexican–American War. Under the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo, Mexico renounces claims to Texas and cedes California and most of New Mexico to the US.

1848 Gold is discovered in the Lower Sacramento valley in California, prompting a massive gold rush.

1848 Seneca Falls Convention: the first national meeting held to discuss women’s rights calls for women’s suffrage.

1850 California joins as a free state, becoming the 31st state in the Union.

1853 Under the terms of the Gadsden purchase, the US acquires parts of southern New Mexico and Arizona so that the Southern Pacific Railroad can be built from Texas to California.

1854 The Republican Party is formed upon the principle of opposing the extension of slavery.

1854 The Kansas–Nebraska Act sets up two new territories and gives settlers the right to decide whether or not to allow slavery. In effect the act ends the Missouri Compromise, as both territories were meant to be free from slavery.

1857 The Dred Scott ruling by the Supreme Court declares that neither Congress nor the people of a territory can abolish slavery. This makes the Missouri Compromise unconstitutional and destroys the balance between free and slave states.

1859 John Brown tries to organize a slave rebellion in Virginia. He is caught, tried for treason, and hanged.

1860 Abraham Lincoln is elected as first Republican president, winning all but one of the northern free states but failing to win a single slave state. South Carolina becomes the first state to secede from the Union over the issue of slavery.

1861–65 Civil War. The conflict begins when seven (later 11) secessionist states form the Confederate States of America. The Confederate States eventually surrender on April 9, 1865, at Appomattox, Virginia, following the fall of Charleston and Richmond.

1861 On February 9, Jefferson Davis, former US Army officer and Secretary of

“A house divided against itself **cannot stand**. I believe this government cannot endure permanently **half slave and half free**.”

ABRAHAM LINCOLN, ILLINOIS REPUBLICAN STATE CONVENTION, JUNE 16, 1858